In Purananuru (183) Ariyapadai Kadandha Nedunchezhiyan (Nedunchezhiyan who defeated the Aryan Army) of Sangam period in his poem emphasised the importance of education. He exhorted everyone to learn from the teacher, irrespective of poverty, giving gifts to him, while pointing out that even a mother favours the learned among the children born to her, and a ruler follows one who is learned. He further added, if a lower class person is learned, even upper class person would bow before him.

Upanishads marked a radical departure from the Vedic beliefs. The term *upa-ni-shad*, meaning 'to sit down near one', refers to the wisdom learned in secret at the feet of a sage, usually in a forest retreat. The Upanishads shifted its emphasis from gods and rituals to mystic knowledge. Education in post-Vedic period was organised in living quarters or private houses of learned teachers. We know about the continuing Gurukula system followed in Varanasi (Banaras/Kasi) from the accounts of the French traveller Bernier. According to him in Banaras masters were sent to different parts of the town to teach in private houses, mainly in the gardens of the rich merchants. Some of these masters had four disciples, others six or seven and the most eminent had twelve. Here teaching was on Vedas, Upanishads, Dharmasastras and epics. The teacher earned livelihood from the *dakshinas*, or customary gifts of the community. There were also charities to house and feed teachers without charge.

Education in Monasteries

The great religious reformers of 6th century BC (BCE), Mahavira, Buddha and Gosala rejected the authority of Vedas. In the age that followed numerous sects emerged of which only Jainism and Buddhism survived into modern times. Jaina and Buddhist monasteries educated and trained their monks. Here students had to remain for a specified period of time to complete their education. Jainas had their religious literature in Ardha-Magadhi and in Pali languages. In south India they established centres for religious instruction near Madurai, Kanchipuram and at Shravanabelagola, Karnataka.

The Tamil word *palli* meaning school referred to Jaina monasteries. The contribution of Jains to Tamil literature was immense. Notable among their celebrated works were *Thirukkural* and *Naladiyar*.



Hiuen Tsang

In contrast to traditional educational centres of ancient types, Jaina and Buddhist centres provided education in large university like campuses. Nalanda in Bihar was a great Buddhist educational centre attracted students from places as far as China and Southeast Asia. These students carried back with them the message of Buddha's teachings. The same was with Vikramshila University that was established in the eighth century AD (CE) by King Dharmapala of Pala dynasty in Bengal. There were monasteries and colleges at Kanchipuram which had gained fame equalling Nalanda. Hiuen Tsang, a Buddhist monk from China visited Kanchipuram during the reign of Narasimha Pallava I.



Nalanda University



Palm leaf manuscripts (Olai Chuvadi)

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